

KITCHEN TABLE: WOMEN OF COLOR PRESS PROUDLY SALUTES

FOUNDING PUBLISHER



BARBARA SMITH

It is impossible in so short a space to pen an adequate tribute to Barbara Smith. As a member of the Combahee River Collective, an organizer on various fronts, and as a writer of her own brilliant essays she was the first to articulate and lay bare the multifaceted complex of oppressions that women of color face in a society that is hostile to them on the basis of gender, race and ethnicity, national origin, socioeconomic class, political identity, and (in the case of lesbians and bisexual women of color) sexual orientation—in short the very core of their beings. As a co-founder, collective member, writer, editor, publisher, and later development team member and consultant to Kitchen Table: Women of Color Press, she has built an enduring testament to the excellence of the work that women of color—politically focused, creatively gifted, intellectually developed, and socially committed—can do. She has strengthened the hearts and nurtured the minds of untold past, present, and future generations of students, activists, artists, and everyday workers who could hardly hope to find a better champion of their lives and rights. She was and is a pioneer who co-edited the Feminist Press title *All the Women Are White, All the Blacks Are Men, But Some of Us Are Brave*, the first-ever comprehensive anthology in the field of Black women's studies, and edited the groundbreaking Kitchen Table Press publication *Home Girls: A Black Feminist Anthology*. Because of these and other writings, speeches, and courses that she has designed and taught she is widely and rightly considered the mother of Black women's studies.

Barbara's charismatic personality, her rare and highly developed intellect, her sensitivity and sense of humor, and her immeasurable facility in the use of both the spoken and the written word have made her a role model and leader in academic and political communities, particularly among the feminist, socialist, people of color, lesbian and gay, Civil Rights, and working class movements in the United States and

throughout the world.

We love and respect Barbara for the deep love and respect she has shown us in tirelessly and unstintingly devoting her life to Kitchen Table: Women of Color Press, an institution as revered for its principled and committed political work as it is for its uncompromising dedication to the creativity of all women of color of the highest artistic and literary merits. Barbara turned the early and still painful childhood loss of her own mother into the positive, honorable, and invaluable goal of mothering, guiding, championing, and ensuring a home for the words and work of her embattled sisters.

It is no surprise to us that Barbara is the recipient of a Schomburg Fellowship, a Bunting Fellowship, and a Lambda Literary Award for Publisher of the Year, among other honors. From the early planning stages in 1980 to the official founding of Kitchen Table in 1981 and through the beginning of 1995, Barbara gave to Kitchen Table often at the expense of her own well-being. That she was able to sustain her various roles at the Press for fifteen years while building an unparalleled reputation and gaining the love and admiration of hundreds of thousands of people of every description is nothing short of earth-shattering.

Those of us who have had the opportunity to know Barbara and work with her are awed by the indisputable fact that we are in the presence of the kind of intellectual, artistic, and political leader who has been seen only rarely in the history of humanity and its struggle to build a just, joyful, and egalitarian society. We know what the liberation struggle can look like at its best—when it embraces the feminine and feminist principles of using creativity, generosity, intellect, and action as the core of the “armed” struggle to combat oppression—because of the work she has done.

We are proud to take up the torch that Barbara has passed on to us. We hope to carry on the work of Kitchen Table Press as fully and energetically as she has done. As an organization representative of the real global majority, we want Barbara to know how proud and grateful we are that she is one of *us*: a race woman and a home girl who has been and remains a cherished part of our lives and who has contributed such inestimable gifts to our history. Now that she has left the staff of Kitchen Table to pursue her new work and dreams, we look forward to the fruits of her future labors. We wish her health, happiness, and inspiration; the recognition and rewards she so richly deserves; and the best of luck in her every endeavor.



—Andrea M. Lockett

Publisher

for Kitchen Table: Women of Color Press